A Healthy Twin Helps Sick Coral Get Better

From: ScienceDaily Top Environment Mined: 2026-10-21 3 min read

Scientists found that badly **bleached** corals can get healthy again by touching healthy corals that are **genetically identical**, like twins. In lab tests, the sick corals recovered in seven weeks. The study came out on October 14 in the journal Science Advances.

Corals are animals. Tiny **algae** live inside them and give them food energy. When ocean water gets too warm, corals lose these **algae** and turn white. This is called bleaching.

The idea started by accident in 2025. In Stanford professor Steve Palumbi's lab, a healthy piece of coral fell against a **bleached** piece from the same coral. Where they touched, the **bleached** piece got its color back.

Student Danny Collins tested 10 pairs of coral pieces. **Bleached** pieces that touched their healthy partner all recovered. The ones kept apart died. The corals' **tissues** joined, and helpful **algae** moved across.

The researchers say this could lead to new ways to help **coral reefs**.

Word Treasure

bleached -- Turned white after losing the tiny algae that live inside.
genetically identical -- Having exactly the same genes, like twins.
algae -- Tiny plant-like living things that make food from sunlight.
tissues -- Groups of cells that make up a living thing's body.
coral reefs -- Large underwater structures built by corals where many sea creatures live.

Background you need

Corals are tiny animals that live together and build coral reefs.

Tiny algae live inside corals, give them food and color, and leave when the water gets too warm.

Break it down

WHO: Stanford scientists Steve Palumbi and Danny Collins
WHAT: Bleached corals got healthy after touching identical healthy corals
WHERE: In a science lab
WHY: Their tissues joined, so helpful algae could move into the sick coral

Why it matters

Healthy coral reefs are homes for many sea animals that kids love to learn about.

Test what you remember

1. What are corals?

(A) Rocks
(B) Fish eggs
(C) Animals
(D) Plants

2. What is bleaching?

(A) When corals lose their algae and turn white
(B) When corals grow taller
(C) When corals move
(D) When corals turn bright red

3. How long did the sick corals take to recover?

(A) Two years
(B) Seven weeks
(C) Ten minutes
(D) One day

4. How did the idea start?

(A) From a fishing trip
(B) From a dream
(C) From a movie
(D) By accident, when two coral pieces touched in a lab

5. What happened to the bleached pieces kept apart?

(A) They grew bigger
(B) They turned green
(C) They died
(D) They recovered

6. How many pairs of coral did Danny Collins test?

(A) 100
(B) 2
(C) 50
(D) 10

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Researchers: This could lead to new ways to help coral reefs.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):